

How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis

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Abstract

Imperial grimoires—that is, manuals on various forms of magic and divination written for or commissioned by royal readers—proliferated across the early modern Persianate world, more than paralleling the (decidedly non-imperial) grimoire boom in Renaissance Europe; but only the latter has been studied to date. This programmatic essay diagnoses the colonialist-Orientalist causes for this wild imbalance in comparative early modern Western intellectual and imperial historiography and outlines a philological way forward. Far from being evidence for “the superstition of the Moslem natives,” such manuals are an indispensable aperture onto precisely those processes—common to Islamdom and Christendom alike—by which we define Western early modernity: textualization, canonization, standardization, confessionalization, centralization, imperialization, bureaucratization, democratization, and mathematization. Yet they also record the religio-cultural and institutional divergences that so distinguish the Islamicate and especially Persianate experience of early modernity from the Latin Christianate.

Keywords

Occult sciences – imperial grimoires – political magic – confessional ambiguity – book history – history of science – early modernity – Eurocentrism – island syndrome – monoculture vs. polyculture

The intellectual history of Western early modernity, Christianate and Islamicate, is defined by new scholarly relationships to the book—especially books on *magic*. In the Latin cosmopolis, as is well known, printing gave rise to a robust grimoire industry; the occult sciences¹ were made accessible as never before. Epitomizing the Renaissance project to retrieve, rationalize, synthesize, and popularize the same is Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa's (1486–1535) *De occulta philosophia libri tres* (Three Books of Occult Philosophy, 1533), the first such manual to be printed, and eventually translated into vernaculars like English (Lehrich). So profitable did it prove, indeed, that a *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* (1559), on geomancy and spirit magic, was manufactured in Agrippa's name to take advantage of an eager market.

But as magic boomed, so did its prosecution. A peculiar feature of Latin Christendom, of course, was its reigning obsession with discovering, and brutally prosecuting, “witchcraft” as essentially, demonically anti-Christian. The great majority of manuals produced by the Renaissance grimoire industry, Catholic and Protestant alike, perished on the inquisitorial pyre—along with many of their authors and readers; much of our knowledge of Latin Christian magic comes rather from the many manuals written to counter it, the *Malleus maleficarum* (Hammer of Witches) of 1486 being the most notorious among them (Kieckhefer, 1–8). Even some of the greatest Renaissance occultists jumped, twofacedly, onto the anti-occultism bandwagon; this includes Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (1463–94), that father of Christian kabbalah, whose anti-Arabic *Disputationes adversus astrologiam divinatricem* (1496) served as model and resource for most later critics of astrology (Hasse, 251–2, 276–8).²

Most perniciously, magic *qua* category was weaponized in furtherance of the great Western rupture that was the Reformation, whereby Protestant polemicists, reprising early Christian antipagan polemic, facilely equated *Catholicism with sorcery* (Hanegraaff, chs. 1–2). (Remarkably, the violently anti-Semitic chauvinism of Martin Luther [1483–1546] himself led this Father of Protesters to lump—quite rightly!—Catholic, Jewish, and Islamic magic together under

1 *I.e.*, astrology, alchemy and various forms of magic and divination. Its nineteenth-century European flavor notwithstanding, I here use “occultism” to denote simply a scholarly preoccupation with one or more of the occult sciences, usually formally designated as such (*al-ʿulum al-khaṭfiyya* or *al-ghariba*) in Arabo-Persian classifications of the sciences, biographical dictionaries, chronicles, *etc.* (see Melvin-Koushki 2017).

2 Needless to say, my conflation here of witchcraft and occultism oversimplifies the matter; it must be stressed, however, that elite and popular occult practices were often pursued and prosecuted in Latinate Europe in a shared *demonological* context.

the rubric of *kabbalah* [Hsia, 135].³) Catholic counter-Reformationists, naturally, returned the favor with equal venom.

Centuries of such vicious, religio-magical othering within Christendom have thus primed Western intellectual historians to expect the same of early modern Islamdom (on the rare occasions, that is, when they attend to it at all), and blinkered them to all evidence to the contrary.⁴ Surely Islamic magic—still routinely panned or simply ignored in the literature as both bad science and bad religion—too must have served but to deepen and widen the rift between Sunni and Shi'i during the golden age of Islamic imperialist confessionalization?

Islam as Magic, Magic as Science, Science as Empire

Hardly. The Latin Christianate experience of early modernity is here, as elsewhere, aberrant; on this front in particular it tracks with contemporary Islamicate data poorly or not at all. While Sunni *vs.* Shi'i rhetoric increasingly abounded as a mode of imperial branding, to be sure, it was precisely *magic* and *manuals* thereof that most made early modern Sunni-Shi'i science and empire conceptually and textually contiguous.⁵ And where magic was *problematically* ubiquitous in Latin Christendom, and occultists often fervently, orgiastically prosecuted,⁶ in post-Mongol Islamdom it was *unproblematically* so: the witch trials and book-burnings that so deranged the former were simply inconceivable in the latter.⁷ In sharp contrast with their contemporary

3 The burgeoning of Hebrew kabbalah and its coeval Arabic twin, lettrism (*'elm al-horuf*), is a defining feature of Western early modernity; see *e.g.* Melvin-Koushki 2018c; *idem* 2017; *idem* 2016.

4 For intellectual-historical purposes, the West is best defined as the half of Afro-Eurasia west of South India, incorporating the Arabic, Persian and Latin cosmopolises, that vast realm where the Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis reigned supreme, and philosophy was pursued in simultaneously mathematical and linguistic terms (Melvin-Koushki 2018c).

5 It is here telling that those contemporary Sunni Persophone scholars who did insist on a neat Sunni-Shi'i divide, like the Naqshbandi master 'Abd al-Rahmān Jāmi (1414–92), also denounced this boom in imperial occult science; see Rizvi; Melvin-Koushki 2012.

6 Thus the declaration by Edward Gibbon (1737–94), projecting his self-consciously Enlightened sensibility onto Rome: "The arts of magic ... were continually proscribed, and continually practised" (1, ch. 25).

7 In the Islamic scholarly tradition, anti-occultist polemic fell largely silent after the fourteenth century; that of Ebn Khaldun (1332–1406)—an ardent, but failed, hammer of witches and burner of books—is the last major such in Arabic letters (Melvin-Koushki 2017, 128–99). This is not to suggest that such polemic did not persist thereafter in some fashion, only that it was far more limited in scope, and rarely fatal for the accused. Thus astrology, for example, that

Latin Christian peers, even the sternest Muslim puritans of the more orthodox seventeenth century, whose fourteenth-century predecessors could still freely polemicize against the occult sciences, were rather constrained to defend them—by *equating Islam with magic*.⁸

They also equated magic with science, both natural and mathematical. Now Europeanist historians of science have in recent decades shown the greatest minds of the Renaissance and the so-called Scientific Revolution (more properly a mathematical one) to have been committed Christian occultists to a man, even in the teeth of the witch craze; indeed, the need to defend their occult science against constant Catholic-*cum*-Protestant charges of witchcraft only made them more alacritous, if also more circumspect, in its pursuit. (I use “occult science” here in the technical and non-polemical pre-modern Arabo-Latin sense, meaning those disciplines wherein one extrapolates from visible data to invisible; for Kepler, Newton, and Bacon, of course, occult sciences like astrology, alchemy, or geomancy were simply good science.⁹) Indeed, Agrippa himself epitomizes this dilemma, or rather cultural crisis: the German humanist-

queen of the occult sciences, was sometimes singled out for criticism by Ottoman scholars, and especially Sufis, as implying astral determinism—yet concurrently institutionalized at the Ottoman court to an unprecedented and unparalleled extent (§en).

- 8 Mohammad Bāqer Majlesi (1627–99), the great Safavid chief jurisconsult (*sheykh al-eslām*) and infamously strict traditionist, is here a case in point. In a remarkable section of his summary Persian legal work on *hodud* punishments and murder law, *Hodud o qesās o diāt*, this leading architect of Safavid Twelver orthodoxy treats of magic or sorcery (Ar. *sehr*, Pers. *jādu*) as being among those serious crimes meriting severe punishment, in this case the death penalty (Majlesi, §1.7.1, 53–7). Majlesi Jr. here proposes a maximalist definition of sorcery as including everything from planetary invocation and jinn subjugation to soothsaying and amuletry: any technique that attempts to influence others’ bodies, hearts or minds falls under this rubric, even harmless illusionism and prestidigitation, as well as all types of talismans, magic-square-based or otherwise—even those harnessing divine names or Qur’anic verses are suspect. Yet he immediately proceeds to claim, wildly counterfactually, that all such forms of sorcery simply went largely extinct with the coming of Islam, and cannot work in properly pious environments like Iran—where every arm, he approvingly reports, is fitted with a Qur’anic or divine-names talisman! For a fuller discussion of this and other cases touched on in this essay, see Melvin-Koushki forthcoming.
- 9 Francis Bacon (1561–1626), for example, father of the modern scientific method, explicitly pursued the rehabilitation of ancient Persian magic, as well as alchemy, astrology, and various forms of divination, as the core of his new *Protestantizing* form of natural philosophy: he invoked magic not as superstition but as superstition’s cure (Josephson-Storm, 44–51). On classifications of the occult sciences as mainstream applied natural and mathematical sciences see Melvin-Koushki 2017. That we now use the pre-modern adjective “occult” (Ar. *khafī*, Lat. *occultus*) exclusively as a slur on a par with “spooky,” and prefer instead neologistic prefixes like “dark,” “sub-” and “para-” to describe the same epistemological category, does not make modern disciplines like astrophysics and psychology—which by definition deal with data unseen—less occult.

theologian's famous and successful defense in 1519 of a woman accused of witchcraft only earned him the lasting ire of the Inquisition (Compagni). But their contemporary Muslim cognates—including in the first place the (occult) philosophers and (occult) scientists of the Timurid, Aq Qoyunlu, Safavid, Mughal, and Ottoman Empires—*had no need for such circumspection*. For smooth, cosmopolitan continuity obtained over insularist rupture: all religio-political propaganda notwithstanding, the trunk of early modern Islamic intellection was Sunni-and-Shi'i, Religion-and-Science, sacralizing-and-mathematizing, manifest-and-occult—and heavily, powerfully *imperialist*.

History of science aside, it is the universalist-imperialist tenor of the equally-robust grimoire industry of the early modern Persian cosmopolis in particular that most serves to distinguish it from its Latin cognate, significantly less vast.¹⁰ Western intellectual historians, still largely thrall to a reflexive Eurocentrism, have yet to digest the basic fact that the Islamicate empires of the post-Mongol Persianate world—culturally equally the West—were far wealthier and more populous, and hence far more multi-confessional and cosmopolitan, than their cognates in China or Western Europe; they together dominated and mediated the Afro-Eurasian ecumene. By the late sixteenth century the Mughal, Safavid, Uzbek, and Ottoman Empires, constituting a single Turco-Mongol Perso-Islamic cultural continuum, held sway over a full third of the human race (*i.e.*, some 160 million of roughly 500 million souls) and comfortably controlled the globalizing Old World economy, centered on the Indian Ocean and the Silk Road (Melvin-Koushki 2018a). (Delhi and Istanbul were the New York and London of the era.) The expansiveness, syncretism, millenarianism, and universalism of competing early modern Islamicate imperial ideologies was thus no mere rhetorical conceit, but a direct reflection of unprecedented religio-cultural realities on the ground.

Chauvinism vs. Ecumenism

Where inquisitorial *chauvinism*, in short, could and did flourish in a decidedly non-imperial, insularist Latinate context, *radical ecumenism* was rather the rule in the contemporary Persianate; and it drove and was driven by a brand of *occult-scientific imperialism* both unprecedented in Islamic history

10 At its greatest extent, the Persian cosmopolis spanned from the eastern Mediterranean and southeastern Europe almost to the Pacific and interpenetrated, uniquely, its mighty Sanskrit and Chinese neighbors, as well as Arabic and Greek; Turkish and Urdu were its primary subsets (see Beecroft).

and unparalleled in Christian (Melvin-Koushki 2018a; Fleischer 2009; Moin; cf. Fleischer 2018). (The European colonialism of later centuries, inspired by Enlightenment ideals and Christian triumphalism in equal measure, was of course hardly occultist!¹¹)

This epochal epistemic, religio-political shift dates to the turn of the fifteenth century, when Persian occult-scientific manuals of unprecedented clarity and accessibility first began to be written for eager Mamluk, Timurid, and Ottoman patrons—many jostling, in competition with dynastic rivals and famed saints alike, to style themselves *saint-philosopher-kings* (Melvin-Koushki 2018a). Occult scientists were equally eager to aid their patrons in that contest. As in Renaissance Europe, their number included the most celebrated scholars and philosophers of the early modern era (for examples, see below); unlike their Latin Christian peers, they succeeded in establishing magic as both mainstream Science-and-Religion and a primary basis for World Empire.

The boom in grimoire production likewise served to consolidate and perpetuate the *confessional ambiguity* that is such a peculiar feature of the post-Mongol era: even at the height of Ottoman–Safavid Sunni–Shi'i imperial rivalry, Sunni occult-scientific manuals routinely became Shi'i classics and Shi'i manuals Sunni, and Safavid occultists were routinely poached by the Ottoman and Mughal courts.¹² (That 'Ali b. Abi Tāleb and various other members of the House of the Prophet (*ahl al-beyt*) were universally held by Sunni and Shi'i alike to be the fountainhead of occult science for the Islamic dispensation—just as Pythagoras, Plato, and Aristotle, disciples of Solomon, were for the Greek—served both to fully Islamicize Hellenic and other late Antique strands of occultism and to render Islamic occultism intrinsically, permanently Imamophilic.¹³) This phenomenon, moreover, represents the larger *both/and* ethos common to Islamicate and especially Persianate societies as a cultural continuum, which explicitly embraced the principles of *ambiguity* and *contradiction* not only religiously but also sexually, literarily, politically, and (occult) philosophically (Ahmed; Bauer; Melvin-Koushki 2019). The contrast with contemporary Catholic-Protestant magic could not be greater.

11 That is to say, it was profoundly *anti-occultist*: continuing long Christian demonological precedent, colonialists tended to see pagan magic behind every native bush (my thanks to Wouter Hanegraaff for this observation).

12 On this phenomenon more broadly, variously termed 'Alid-loyalism by Marshall Hodgson, Twelver Sunnism (*tasannon-e esnā-'ashari/davāzdah-emāmi*) by Mohammad-Taqi Dāneshpazhuh and Rasul Ja'fariān, and Imamophilia by the present author, see Melvin-Koushki 2012, 69–73.

13 On the equation of 'Ali with Pythagoras, for example, see *ibid.*, ch. 6.

The Mediterranean Book Boom

Whence this golden age of imperial Persian grimoires? Considerable evidence suggests it to be the upshot of twelfth- and thirteenth-century developments specific to the Mediterranean zone. This, the “age of esotericism and its disclosure” (Halbertal, 5), was centrally defined by the emergence of Hebrew *kabbalah* and Arabic *lettrism* in Islamic Iberia, whence the Judeo-Islamic pair spread east along the Mediterranean’s northern and southern shores respectively. The Reconquista would later scatter Jewish kabbalists throughout Western Europe—inspiring, in no small part, the doctrine of *Hebraica veritas*, precursor of the *sola scriptura* war-cry of the Reformation. During this first phase, however, kabbalah-lettrism was textually propagated by small, secretive, spiritually-elitist communities very much concerned to exclude the uninitiated: *esotericist reading communities* (Gardiner 2014, ch. 2).

Yet these esotericist readers would appear to be the first in Western history to treat books as *initiatory devices* in their own right; as Noah Gardiner has shown, the lettrist-kabbalist manuals they produced represent “a veritable *apotheosis* of the reader in an age of readers such as the Muslim world had never seen before” (Gardiner 2014, 340). Further, they rendered the world itself a (Hebrew-Arabic) mathematical text, a second scripture to be decoded—and magically recoded—by the self-divinizing reader.

In the fourteenth century, wracked and cleaved open by the apocalypse that was the Black Death, which sharpened anew the equally-cleaving Mongol apocalypse of the thirteenth, the occult-scientific cat permanently escaped this esotericist bag: Mamluk Cairo became the epicenter of the occultist renaissance that would define the Arabophone and Persophone worlds for centuries after, transforming Islamicate knowing to no less degree than the parallel Renaissance to the northwest transformed Christianate (Gardiner 2014; Melvin-Koushki 2017, 131–2). (Pico’s Christian kabbalah is here emblematic.) But only in the former, as noted, was it successfully imperialized. Arabo-Persian imperial manuals on various occult sciences, including lettrism, geomancy, astrology, and alchemy, suddenly proliferated, and continued to do so through at least the seventeenth century—and in many regions to the early twentieth. (Islam, of course, had no Enlightenment, and hence no corresponding Endarkenment; and its rupturous if shambling Reformation was colonialism and Protestantization.) Crucially, taking a page from esotericist precedent, but breaking definitively with the secretiveness and exclusivity of the same, their de-esotericizing authors were among the first in the Islamicate scholarly tradition—which had privileged orality over textuality from its inception—to explicitly vaunt these manuals as standalone sources of knowledge

(cf. El-Rouayheb). Readers, and especially royal readers, began to use them as such.

That is to say: To understand the sea-change that defined Western early modernity, featuring sweeping *philological revolutions* that drove an unprecedented boom in textual (manuscript and print) culture and rendered books authoritative in their own right, we cannot afford to ignore the Arabo-Persian grimoires that epitomize it.¹⁴ Why, then, have almost all such manuals been totally ignored in the literature?¹⁵

Here *printing* has been a major historiographical stumbling block: its advent is tacitly assumed or explicitly stated to be the measure of early modern Westernness as a rule. Thus many dozens of excellent studies celebrate the rise of printing in Western Europe; vanishingly few do the same for the mighty “post-classical” manuscript traditions of the Arabophone, much less Persophone and Turcophone, realms. (Classico- and Arabocentrism, like Eurocentrism, their parent, still plague the study of Islamicate civilization.) Yet clearly the long disinterest in printing in the Islamicate world did not cripple its book cultures in the slightest; to the contrary, a wide-scale adoption of printing, while known and very modestly deployed (in the Mamluk production of amulets, for instance), would have been precisely a hobble to and disruptor of the crucial sociopolitical functions of said cultures.

Books, quite simply, *were more socially important in early modern Islamdom than in Christendom*: for there they enshrined and activated social relationships in fluid ways more rigidly substituted by university and church hierarchies in Latin Europe. As such, they were produced at a much greater rate and in far more variety in the Islamicate world than the Christianate and, as a rule, were considerably more encyclopedic in scope (Hirschler 2016 and 2013; Hanna; Erünsal; Muhanna; Melvin-Koushki 2016 and 2018c). Mamluk Egypt was thus birthplace to a golden age of occultism and encyclopedism both—and *occultist encyclopedism* (Gardiner 2017).

14 For a survey, synthesis and critique of recent scholarship on these Western philological revolutions, see Melvin-Koushki 2018c.

15 The egregious state of Western grimoire studies is epitomized by Davies's recent synthetic study of the genre (2009), which presents—inexplicably, inexcusably, and in merest passing—Maslama al-Qortobi's (906–64) seminal *Ghāyat al-hakim* (Goal of the Sage, Lat. *Picatrix*) as an anonymous twelfth-century work, and the even more seminal *Shams al-ma'āref al-kobrā* (Great Sun of Knowledge) attributed to the Maghrebi Sufi-mage Ahmad al-Buni (d. btw. 1225–33)—in actuality an unstable compilation gradually assembled between the fourteenth and seventeenth centuries around an original Bunian core (Gardiner 2014, 6, 157–8)—as both an authentic product of the thirteenth century and representative of *timeless Islamic folk magic* (Davies, 26, 166–7)! On any other Arabic grimoire (we cannot hope for Persian) there is not a word.

Persian Imperial Grimoires

To help combat the blatantly colonialist-Orientalist double standard that still cripples early modern Western intellectual history—whereby printed Latin grimoires like Agrippa’s patently merit much study, but their equally or more influential unprinted Persian cognates precisely *none*—I have identified, and am editing and translating, a number of pivotal occult-scientific manuals produced in Timurid–Aq Qoyunlu–Safavid Iran and Mughal India that testify to this cultural sea-change. All, naturally, are unpublished and most entirely unstudied to date; and in the rare event their authors—who include, again, some of the most celebrated scholars and philosophers of the early modern era—have been grappled with in modern scholarship, occult science has been assiduously deleted from their surviving oeuvres.¹⁶ Among those that may most profitably be compared and contrasted with contemporary Latin cognates like the *Three Books of Occult Philosophy* and its geomantic *Fourth* going forward are the following nine:

- 1) Lotf-Allāh Nishāpuri Samarqandi’s (*fl.* 1409) *Kholāsat al-bahrayn* (Epitome of the Two Seas), an innovative Timurid pairing of geomancy and talismanically-operative magic squares (the “two seas” of the title) (Melvin-Koushki 2018b, 166–7, 183–4);
- 2) Ebn Torka Esfahāni’s (1369–1432) *Resāla-ye horuf* (On the Letters), the first explicitly imperialist treatise on lettrist theory and practice for the benefit of an ambitious Timurid ruler (Melvin-Koushki 2012, 88–90, 163–89);
- 3) The same author’s *So’l al-moluk* (Query of Kings), a fuller handbook of Timurid political letter magic (*ibid.*, 119–20, 507–27);
- 4) Jalāl al-Din Davāni’s (1426/7–1502) *Tohfa-ye ruhāni* (A Spiritual Boon), a summary Aq Qoyunlu treatise on political letter magic in the Timurid mode, written for a Khalji sultan of central India (Melvin-Koushki forthcoming);
- 5) Hosayn Vā’ez Kāshefi’s (1436/7–1505) *Asrār-e Qāsemi* (Qāsemian Secrets), on illusionism and terrestrial magic—a Timurid manual considerably

16 Contrast here the many dozens of excellent studies of and monographs on Agrippa and his occult philosophy published over the last century and a half. The example of Ebn Torka is here representative: this foremost occult philosopher and imperial ideologue of the Timurid period, hailed the “Spinoza of Iran” by Mohammad-Taqi Dāneshpazhuh, has been received solely as an apolitical “mystical philosopher” linking Ebn ‘Arabi (1165–1240) with Mollā Sadrā (1572–1635), and his consciously revolutionary philosophical-imperial project wholly ignored (Melvin-Koushki 2012, 2–11).

- expanded in the Safavid period to include sections on talismans, astral magic, and alchemy;¹⁷
- 6) His son ‘Ali Safi Kāshefi’s (1463–1533) *Herz al-amān men fetan al-zamān* (Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time), a Timurid-Safavid, Sunni-Shi‘i *summa* of political lettrism (Melvin-Koushki 2012, 272–80);
 - 7) Shāh Mollā Monajjem Shirāzi’s (fl. 1576) *Jahān al-raml* (World of Geomancy), the first “international” manual on that science, written for the Safavid shah (Melvin-Koushki 2018b, 169–72);
 - 8) Its Mughal imperial adaptation and expansion by the former’s student Hedāyat-Allāh Monajjem Shirāzi (fl. 1593), *Qavā‘ed al-hedāya* (Principles of Guidance), which constructs a universal geomantic canon—one that remained stable through at least the nineteenth century (*ibid.*, 170–4);
 - 9) Mahmud Dehdār Shirāzi’s (fl. 1576) *Mafātiḥ al-maghāliq* (Keys to All Locks), a comprehensive Safavid lettrist and astral-magical grimoire not dissimilar to Agrippa’s, and popular throughout the Persophone world to the present (Melvin-Koushki forthcoming).

While examples could easily be multiplied, I here highlight the above as being especially explicitly imperialist in tenor: they pair lettrist or geomantic divination with lettrist and astral and spirit magic in furtherance of the projects of their aspiring saint-philosopher-king patrons. For the first tells you the future, and the second enables you to change it. This prospect, needless to say,

17 This seminal Timurid–Safavid grimoire is the sole exception to this universal neglect, though it too has only been studied in preliminary fashion, and remains unedited. In his brief 2003 article, moreover, the first on the subject, Lory draws a number of untenable and ahistorical conclusions as to the nature and provenance of the *Asrār-e Qāsemi*; this is due primarily to his unquestioning reliance on, yet spotty reading of, a single undated, late nineteenth-century Indian lithograph copy, featuring three further main sections (on *limiā*, *himiā*, and *kimiā*, or talismans, astral magic, and alchemy) obviously interpolated in the Safavid period. (In particular, he misidentifies the Sheykh Bahā’ al-Din Mohammad frequently mentioned in the section on talismanic magic (*limiā*) as preeminent Safavid mage—obviously Sheykh Bahā’i (1547–1621), Safavid *sheykh al-eslām* and renaissance man extraordinaire—as Sheykh Bahā’ al-Din Mohammad Naqshband (1318–89), eponymous founder of the Naqshbandiya Sufi order, and simply ignores the other Safavid sages here cited, together with the Safavid shahs and Qezelbāsh amirs they are reported to have occult-scientifically served.) Subtelny’s forthcoming study provides a corrective and indicates the way forward for studying both this hybrid Timurid-Safavid manual of magic and its many early modern Persianate kin; most importantly, she identifies the Safavid interpolator of the *limiā* section as Jalāl al-Din Monajjem Yazdi (d. c. 1619), court astrologer and historian to Shah ‘Abbās I (r. 1587–1629), and responsible, significantly, for an important astrological manual of his own, the *Tohfāt al-monajjemīn*. On Safavid political magic more broadly, see Melvin-Koushki forthcoming.

was of great attractiveness to ruling elites, messianic or otherwise. (An exception is Kāshefi Jr.'s *Herz al-amān*, which promises rather to enable officials and bureaucrats to magically mind-control sovereigns to an unprecedented extent—shades of the bureaucratization process so definitive of Western early modernity [*cf.* Hemmat].)

Of equal attractiveness to aspiring Muslim world emperors and self-styled second Alexanders was the emphatically “internationalist,” perennialist and radically ecumenical project of these manuals, which construct an unbroken West-East, Ancient-Modern, Sunni-Shi'i scholarly continuum. That is to say: they consciously embody and enact the Alexandrian imperialist-occultist ethos of the vastly influential *Serr al-asrār* (Secret of Secrets) of Pseudo-Aristotle, the tenth-century Arabic mirror-for-princes that as *Secretum secretorum* became almost as popular (if less successfully enacted) in Latinate Europe, wherein the father of peripatetic philosophy advises his ambitious protégé—in an overtly *Iranian* mode—that world empire can only be achieved and maintained by means of astrology, alchemy, physiognomy, and magic.¹⁸

Most significantly for history of science, moreover, the explicitly Neopythagorean-Neoplatonic thrust of these and many other contemporary Persian manuals bids their royal readers to *read the world*—and then *rewrite it*. It is precisely this thrust, this lettrist-kabbalist doctrine of the Two Books, that drove the *mathematization of the cosmos* (Melvin-Koushki 2017). For all that the persistent Eurocentrism and scientism of current history of science still violently disappears Islamicate high occultism from the story of Western early modernity (and hence colonialist-capitalist modernity itself), such examples suggest that the quest to control the world imperially as well as scientifically was in no way exclusive to Latin Christendom, but common to the early modern Western world as a whole, and drove its shared boom in (occult-)scientific manual culture.

18 Epitomizing this conscious enactment is a passage in the Safavid-era interpolated section on *limiā* in Kāshefi Sr.'s *Asrār-e Qāsemi* wherein an astral-magical operation for harnessing the Sun to humble one's political enemies is credited to Plato (*sic*), who thereby rendered Alexander a world-conqueror; significantly, it immediately follows a similar operation invented by Seyyed Hosayn Akhlāti (d. 1397), the famed Tabrizi Kurdish alchemist-lettrist, personal physician to the Mamluk sultan Barquq (r. 1382–99) and teacher to the most influential occultists of the next generation, including in the first place Ebn Torka (Kāshefi, 115; Melvin-Koushki 2012, 2019). On the strong “Sasanian flavor” of the *Serr al-asrār*, see van Bladel.

Against an Insularist and Ecocidal History of Western Magic

Embattled Christian magic should therefore no longer be used as the touchstone by which to measure Islamic magic, but triumphant Islamic magic Christian. For such an intra-Western comparative procedure reveals the Western European witch craze to be in cultural-evolutionary terms but a classic symptom of *island syndrome*, featuring morphological distortion (both dwarfism and gigantism), species poverty, source disharmony and, most direly, *information destruction*.¹⁹ The same syndrome, I contend, has crippled Western and especially Islamicate intellectual historiography in its evolution over the last two centuries: it continues to be written out of all proportion to the surviving sources, and information on mainstream Islamicate magic destroyed by colonialist-Orientalist mal- or inattention, which simply amputates and discards the greater part of the Western occult-scientific tradition as not-West, not-philosophy, not-science.²⁰ Or to invoke the allied ecological metaphor of the *field*: fundamentalist Euro-American farmer-historians of science and of religion alike continue to ecocidally and eugenically root out occult science as *alien weed*—its luxuriant Islamicate strains above all—from the industrialized monocultural field that is Western intellectual history, continue to colonially disdain the “messier” but infinitely more sustainable polycultural Three Sisters approach—here Science-Religion-Magic—as *illegible* and hence *uncivilized* (cf. Scott; Kimmerer; Pierotti; Shiva).²¹

To rather understand, with our Muslim authors, Islam as Magic—which is to say, as Science-and-Religion, as World Empire—, let us intellectual historians to the Arabo-Persian grimoires that too were constitutive of textualizing, centralizing, imperializing, bureaucratizing, confessionalizing, democratizing, and mathematizing Western early modernity. Let us desist from historiographically burning Muslim witches and their books.

19 Although many social scientists believe the biology-culture divide to be ultimately theoretically bridgeable, the applicability of Darwinian evolution to the question of historical change in human cultures remains, of course, hotly contested; my invocations of “cultural evolution” and “island syndrome” here are therefore primarily metaphorical, and my summary of the latter’s symptoms taken from recent textbooks on the subject. Nevertheless, the remarkably close structural parallels between island ecologies on the one hand and both early modern Latin Christendom and current Western intellectual historiography on the other—equally blithely, doggedly insularist—are instructive.

20 My thanks to Nükhet Varlık for her inspired suggestion of both metaphors.

21 I.e., the archetypal form of Native American polycropping, common in precolonial agricultural practice globally, here featuring maize, beans, and squash.

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